appearance these several old temples presented’. The unintentionally amusing account below was part of what Burt recorded that day:

> I found in the ruins of Khajuraho seven large Hindoo temples, most beautifully and exquisitely carved as to workmanship, but the sculptor had at times allowed his subject to grow rather warmer than there was any absolute necessity for his doing; indeed, some of the sculptures here were extremely indecent and offensive; which I was at first much surprised to find in temples that are professed to be erected for good purposes, and on account of religion. But the religion of the Hindoos could not have been very chaste if it induced people under the cloak of religion, to design the most disgraceful representation to desecrate their ecclesiastical erections. The palky bearers, however, appeared to take great delight at the sight of those to them very agreeable novelties, which they took good care to point out to all present.[2]

In the 1850s, archaeologist Alexander Cunningham documented the site more formally but he too was scandalized by the sculptures, finding them ‘highly indecent’, ‘disgustingly obscene’ and ‘highly indelicate’. He wrote, ‘everywhere there are number of female figures who are represented dropping their clothes, and thus purposely exposing their persons’.



Figure 2. Vishwanath Temple panel